The Last Flapper

By William Luce

VOICE: **(Pg 11-13)** *(As nurse)* Attention, nursing staff. The recreation room is being painted, so please remind patients that the party tonight is in the cafeteria.

ZELDA: *(ZELDA enters the dimly lighted office of Dr. Carroll)* Dr. Carroll? *(Surprised)* He's not here. *(To audience)* It's three o'clock, isn't it? *(Looks into the hall, then turns back to the room)* Dr. Carroll, come out, come out, wherever you are.

VOICE: *(As nurse)* Your attention, please. Dr. Carroll has been called away on an emergency. His afternoon appointments are cancelled

ZELDA: Hallelujah! No three o'clock inquisition! *(Checks the hallway. Returns to the desk. With a letter opener, she begins prying open the locked file drawer)* Thank you, Doctor, don't mind if I do. *(Drawer opens; finding files)* "Highland Hospital. Robert S. Carroll, M.D. Confidential." *(Smiling)* Not anymore. *(Riffling through files)* Here's Katie's. All she does is wander around, yelling . . . "Would somebody call me a cab?" *(More files)* Here's George's. *(Opening and reading)* "Permit patient the use of cosmetics on all but visiting days." *(To audience)* George is a long, tall man who roams the halls in evening gowns. He says his father wanted a boy; his mother wanted a girl. I guess they were both satisfied. *(More files)* *"Fitzgerald, Zelda."* *(Begins to silently read. Several beats. Angrily, she hurls her file to the floor)*

INTRODUCTION

Zelda Fitzgerald was a cultural icon of the 1920s. Dubbed the 'first American flapper by her husband F. Scott Fitzgerald; she wore short skirts, listened to jazz and flaunted her disdain for what was considered acceptable behavior. But Zelda also suffered from a form of mental illness and spent the last decade of her life at Highland Hospital, a North Carolina sanitarium. Based on her letters and stories, this is her story.

The Last Flapper by William Luce

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ZELDA: **(Pg 14)** *(Picks up pages at random studies each page and lets it fall again. Reads aloud)* "Fitzgerald, Zelda. Schizophrenic. Patient rebels against authority. Do not stir up the patient. Relieve her of having to make decisions, which aggravates her disorder. Avoid confrontation." *(To audience)* Excuse me for smiling. People think I've thought of something witty. The fact is, my smile is uncontrollable, and it terrifies me. I'm simply a neurotic woman who's reached the end of her physical resources and is exhausted.

(Pg 15-16) *(Picks up another sheet of paper from the floor and peruses it. It prompts a memory)* I was always an excitement eater. When I was a child, I phoned the fire department. "Hello, Mr. Fireman? There's a little girl stuck on top of a house! The gray and white one at Six Pleasant Avenue. Hurry!" I got the ladder, climbed onto the roof, kicked the ladder away and waited. The fire engine came clanging down the street, and the neighbors ran out to see what the hell was - *(Suddenly distracted)* Do you know something else? Nobody's ever sent me a get-well card. Isn't that rotten? "Sorry you've gone insane, Zelda." Even *that* would do. But not a word. *(beat)* **(Pg 17-18)** And I can't dance. They won't let me. "No dancing, Mrs. Fitzgerald." Now you talk about therapy. That could really help me. But Dr. Carroll says that's part of my problem. Just because my husband went and blabbed to him about Paris, and how I made myself sick going to ballet class eight hours a day. Scott couldn't realize that dancing was my refuge from the chaos in our lives. *(beat)*

(lost in another memory) **(Pg 23)** *(Now the young Zelda with a southern accent. She jumps up, extending her left hand) (To Mamma)* Mamma! Oh, looka here. It's from Scott. *(Pause)* It's an engagement ring, Mamma. It's his mother's. Isn't it grand? *(Pause)* Oh, Mamma, I'm practically nineteen. *(Gazing at the ring)* And it fits, Mamma. *(Dreamily)* Mrs. Francis Scott Fitzgerald. It sorta says "soon" to me. Just sings it. Oh, just wait til' I wear it Saturday night to the Country Club dance.

(Emerges from her memory to speak eloquently to the audience) **(Pg 26)** In Montgomery in 1920, there was a time, a quality, that pertained to nowhere else. It began about half

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

past six on an early summer evening, with the flicker and splatter of the corner streetlights going on. And it lasted till the great incandescent globes were black with moths and beetles, and the children were called to bed from the dusty streets, and the grownups sat out on the porches, talking. *(Pause)*

(Reverts to young Zelda. In her mind, she is being fitted for her wedding dress) **(Pg 27)** *(To Mamma)* Oh, Mamma, this'll be the prettiest wedding dress ever! *(Twirls with excitement)* Scott says we're gonna be married in St. Patrick's Cathedral, in the rectory. *(soft smile; she speaks again to the audience)* **(Pg 29-30)** Scott says when he first saw me in 1918, he thought my hair looked honey-yellow. I remember the dress I was wearing -- white silk with a chiffon tunic floating over it. And a large-brimmed hat as big as a manhole cover. And long streamers down my back. And a fan. Oh, my, a genuine Southern belle. He was beautiful as men are not meant to be, with violet eyes and dark lashes and a straight nose and sensitive mouth.

(Pg 31-32) *(Now the young Zelda, she becomes flirtatious) (To Scott)* Francis Scott Fitzgerald? What a remarkable name. Are you related to Francis Scott Key, the man who wrote that awful song that nobody can sing? *(Pause)* You are? Well, don't be offended, Lieutenant, but I hope it never becomes our national anthem. Woodrow Wilson's the only one who likes it, and he's such an ol' coot. ***You*** don't like it, do you? *(Pause)* You ***do****?* Maybe I should listen to it a few more times with that in mind. *(Pause)* My name is Zelda Sayre. Z-E-L-D-A. I got named after a gypsy queen in a novel Mamma was reading just 'fore she had me.

(long beat as her memory jumps in time, there is a marked change in her demeanor) Scott, why did you marry me? *(As Scott)* Because you have some sense of the seriousness of life. *(To Scott)* Seriousness? *(To audience)* Me? *(To Scott)* Why, I'm the original Flapper, my silly Goofo. I'm down there in black and white in your own novels as a proud and selfish little fool. There isn't a serious bone in my body. Remember? *(to audience)* During that time, I bobbed my hair**,** lost my Southern accent and went into battle.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(laughs rather uncontrollably) I jumped into a fountain in my evening clothes and rode down Fifth Avenue one hot summer evening on top of a taxi. We both did. *(To Scott)* Didn't we, Scott? *(To audience)* I was on the hood and he was on the roof.

(Pg 49) I had a bad reputation, all right. I smoked rabbit tobacco in a com-cob pipe, and if there wasn't any gin, I drank corn liquor cut with coke. **(Pg 46)** *(As Mama)* No lady ever steps out the front door without fastening her gloves. And no lady ever lets her bare feet touch the floor. We are genteel Southern ladies, and don't you forget it. **(Pg 49)** *(chastised; to Mamma, quietly)* Yes, Mamma.

(She shakes off the melancholy and speaks with great animation to the audience) In Montgomery there was this ice-cream parlor on Dexter Avenue. Harry's Place. **It** was the local jelly joint. All the boys gathered there. I called them my "Jelly Beans." They just loafed around. You know how boys do when they don't have dates. Once they drove by the house, yelling my name: Zelda! Zelda! Zelda! I ran out on the veranda. *(Calling)* My Jelly Beans! All my beautiful Jelly Beans! I love you! *(To audience)* Daddy was home and he was livid. He said, *(in father's voice)* "Your personal conduct is outrageous! How dare you make a spectacle of yourself!" *(To Daddy defiantly)* I don't care. I've got a right to do anything I want! (she wilts, and a deep melancholy comes over her)

(Pg 33) Here's to the Flapper, who's growing old at last. She's come to none of the predicted bad ends but has gone where all good flappers go - into marriage and boredom and convention. (bolstering her strength) Who gives a damn about convention? Not me. The world isn't going to suffocate me. That's what this flapper's all about. Climb to the top and live high. And if the fine's a heavy one, what the hell! There's only one act of significance. *You take what you want when you want it! (Pause)*

(Pg 35) *(To audience, bewildered)* Dear God, that desperate nostalgia to be young. It's so

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

painful. I used to say to myself, "Zelda, you'll be all right for another five years. You'll be pretty that long. It takes a good fifty years for time to batter down a woman's looks and crumple her charm." Look at me! The glamorous Mrs. F. Scott Fitzgerald and her Elizabeth Arden face - gone to pot.

(Pg 50-51) *(Hears a voice in her head that captures her attention)* No, Doctor, I do ***not*** want to talk about my husband. Anyway, he's dead. He died eight years ago. A heart attack in Hollywood. *(Reminiscing)* Scott was the prophet of his generation. The Jazz Age. And - and - *(She gropes for the next idea, her thoughts are disjointed, and she becomes increasingly agitated)* And I'm fed up with these wistful, tragic silhouettes of Scott and Zelda. People want to bank on gods? Well, that's too bad! *(clutching her hands to her face, she feels the pain; sobbing)* He came home last night, and he smashed me in the nose. He broke down the bathroom door and punched me in the nose. **(Pg 55-57)** *(her sobbing is replaced by anger)* He says I've failed him. Well, it's just barely possible he's failed me, the sonuvabitch. *(To Scott)* No, Scott, I am not reproaching you. You blamed me when you couldn't write, when you know the real reason was you were out half the night with the boys, drinking yourself unconscious. *(Pause as she listens to a voice in her head)* No, goddamn it, you let me finish! You whined about your lonely struggle against gifted and talented writers, and how I was only a third-rate writer and a third-rate ballet dancer. If that was true, then why the hell did you put your name on my short stories? Why did you help yourself to my diaries and letters?

VOICES: Help!

ZELDA: Did you hear that?

VOICES: Help! Help! Help!

ZELDA: I used to hear voices only once in a while, but now I hear them all the time. "Help!" they cry. *(Impatiently)* Oh, I know they're inside me! Don't you think I know that?

VOICES: *(As Scott)* Zelda! Zelda! Zelda!

ZELDA: *(Screaming)* Scott, I'm here! Come and get me! Please, come and get me!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

(Crumples, sobbing. Long beat, then quietly to audience) Nobody, not even the poets, can measure how much a heart can hold. But hearts perish in public institutions.

CLOSING

That night, March 10, 1948 – a fire broke out at Highland Hospital. Witnesses could hear the harrowing, desperate screams of women on the top floor where flames held them hostage and consumed their lives. There was no way out—some of the windows were locked, others were barred by heavy chains. Zelda and four other women on the top floor, having been given strong sedatives to induce sleep, died in the blaze.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: William Luce
ISBN: 978-0573691683
Publisher: Samuel French, Inc.
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1990

AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2002 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
Il State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY